

# Vinyl's opportunity does not end at release week

U.S. recorded music | Undral Ganbaatar

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Your music collection once occupied a shelf. Now, millions of albums fit behind a search bar. CDs and vinyl might seem destined for the same dusty corner: both physical formats, seemingly made obsolete for listening by streaming. Yet vinyl sales have grown while CDs have lost ground.

Between 2015 and 2024, U.S. vinyl album units more than tripled, while CD units fell by roughly 72%. By 2025, vinyl outsold CDs by more than seventeen million copies. Streaming made physical ownership optional for both. **Why did one format gain ground while the other lost it?**

We started with the straightforward explanations: price and the kinds of music people were buying. But the more interesting clue emerged when we compared individual albums. Vinyl's annual lead did not consistently appear in opening-week sales. That raised another question: were we looking too early?

## More copies, despite the price gap

First, is vinyl's revenue growth merely a story about higher prices? RIAA's legacy series shows vinyl *units* rising from 13.7 million in 2015 to 43.6 million in 2024, while CDs fell from 117.1 million to 32.9 million. The latest report extends the divergence through 2025, with revisions to the preceding year.

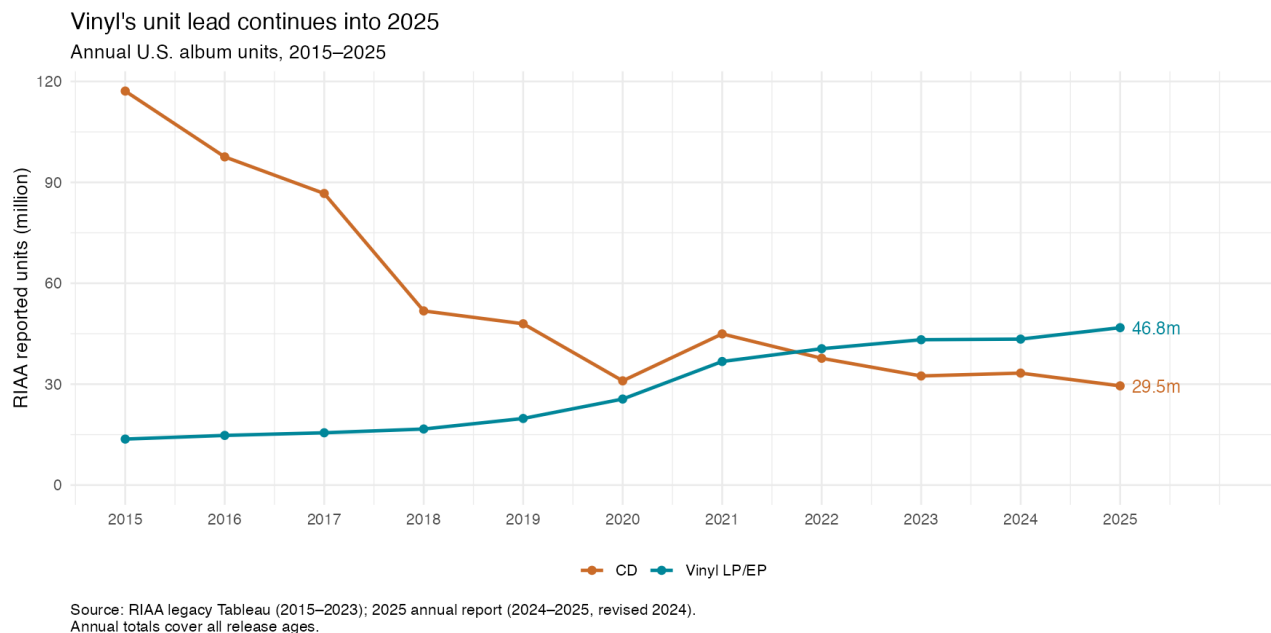


Figure 1. Annual units. Legacy Tableau through 2023; the latest RIAA report supplies revised 2024 and 2025 figures. Revenue calculations use the consistent legacy series through 2024.

Perhaps vinyl became more affordable relative to CD? It generated approximately twice the revenue per copy in both 2015 and 2024. In 2024, the figures were \$33.07 for vinyl and \$16.43 for CD. This ratio did not narrow. Vinyls managed this feat whilst continually charging twice as much as CDs on average. Not bad for a format that also asks you to get up and flip it over.

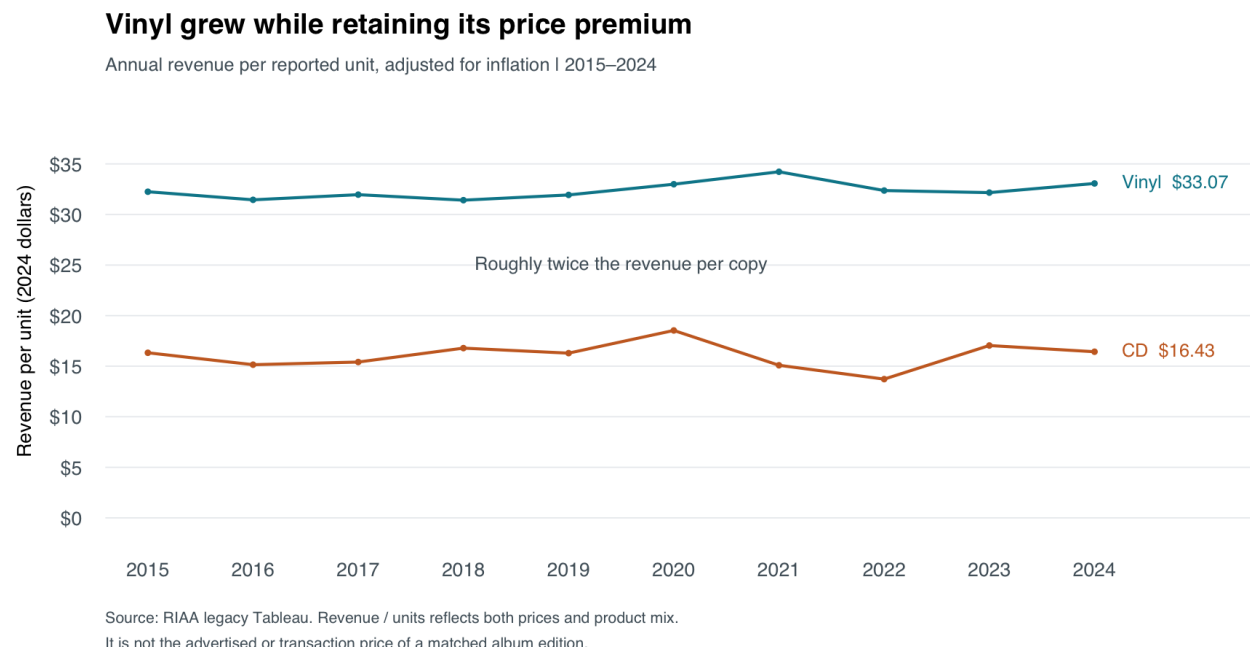


Figure 2. Revenue per copy in 2024 dollars. This measure reflects prices and product mix; it is not a matched comparison of identical album editions.

## Did vinyl-friendly genres simply get bigger?

Another possibility is that genres already favoring vinyl captured more of the market. That could lift vinyl overall without changing purchasing patterns within any genre.

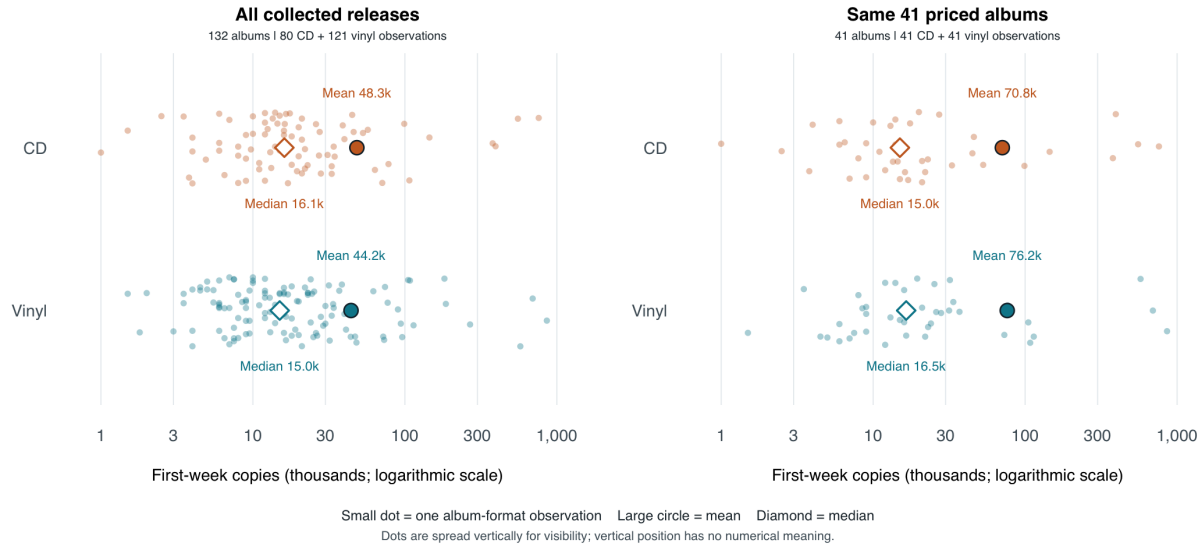
Country provides a useful counterexample. Between 2019 and 2022, country vinyl purchases rose from 713,000 to 1.92 million, even as total country album purchases fell. Vinyl’s share of all country album purchases, including digital albums, increased from 6.6% to 27.2%. Here, vinyl expanded inside a shrinking album market: a country-wide sales boom cannot explain it. [Luminate](#)

This does not settle genre composition’s national contribution, but it shows why looking within genres—and individual recordings—is worthwhile. We next asked whether CD and vinyl versions of the same albums reproduced the national pattern.

## Opening week gives a less consistent answer

Our collection contains 201 publicly reported first-week observations across 132 albums. Across all collected releases, CDs had the higher average; among the 41 albums with both formats and advertised prices, vinyl had only a slight higher average. Medians were much closer in both samples.

## The opening-week comparison changes with the sample



Source: dataset constructed by web scraping publicly available U.S. first-week album sales reports.

Coverage depends on reported data availability and may not represent the wider market.

Figure 3. Small dots show individual U.S. first-week sales observations; large circles mark means and diamonds mark medians. The horizontal axis is logarithmic. The left compares different album sets; the right includes both formats for each album.

Could price help explain the difference? In the 41-album sample, a regression model including format and price estimated a positive price coefficient: higher-priced releases tended to sell more. Adding an indicator for each album changed that estimate to slightly negative. Neither estimate was statistically conclusive. The comparison is consistent with price reflecting differences between releases, rather than a benefit from charging more.

Popular artists or collectible extras could support both higher prices and stronger sales. Comparing formats within the same album holds shared artist and recording characteristics constant, but does not remove differences in packaging, promotion or availability. Our advertised standard-edition prices also do not measure the price of every copy sold. The model comparisons and uncertainty intervals are in the appendix.

The vinyl coefficient likewise remained inconclusive. These results did not reveal a consistent opening-week advantage, but annual sales cover much more than new releases. If vinyl purchases continue longer or draw on a different mix of recordings, opening week could miss an important part of the story.

## What happens after launch?

For eight albums with published CD and vinyl counts at launch and a later endpoint, we calculated:

$$\text{Vinyl unit premium (\%)} = 100 \times (\text{Vinyl units} / \text{CD units} - 1)$$

A premium of +20% means 120 vinyl copies for every 100 CDs. Moving from +20% to +30% is a ten-percentage-point increase in the premium, not a change in market share.

Six of the eight albums improved on this measure. The average increase was 5.8 percentage points; the median was 4.1. For Taylor Swift's *Red (Taylor's Version)*, vinyl went from selling 21% fewer copies than CD in opening week to approximately 10% more cumulatively by week seven. Adele's *30* remained CD-led, but vinyl's deficit narrowed from 71% to 65% by week six.

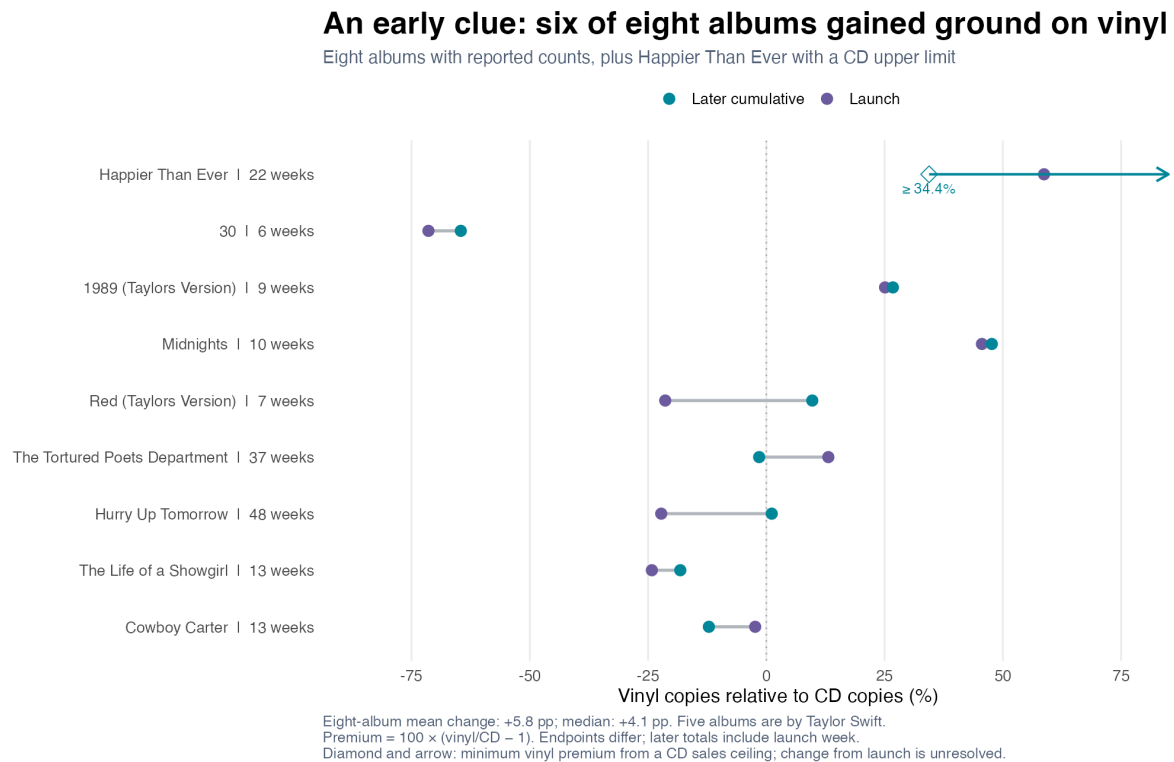


Figure 4. Eight albums with reported counts plus Happier Than Ever, whose later CD sales have an upper bound. Its diamond and arrow mark a minimum vinyl premium; its change is unresolved. Endpoints differ.

This only offers an exploratory clue: five were Swift albums, and later endpoints ranged from six to 48 weeks. Restocks, promotion and format availability could influence these trajectories. The complete expanded analysis is in the appendix.

## Older recordings take a larger share of vinyl sales

This made us curious: could vinyl have a longer sales life than CD? If so, we might expect older recordings to account for a larger share of vinyl purchases. We examined the age mix of sales within each format to see whether that pattern appeared.

In the first half of 2022, approximately 12.9 million catalog vinyl copies were purchased, compared with 10.0 million catalog CDs. Older recordings also accounted for a larger proportion of vinyl purchases in both periods examined, as the chart below shows. Catalog generally means recordings older than eighteen months, subject to chart and radio-activity exceptions. [Luminate figures reported by Billboard](#)

## Older recordings account for a larger share of vinyl purchases

Catalog share of U.S. copies purchased in each format; gray remainder is current releases

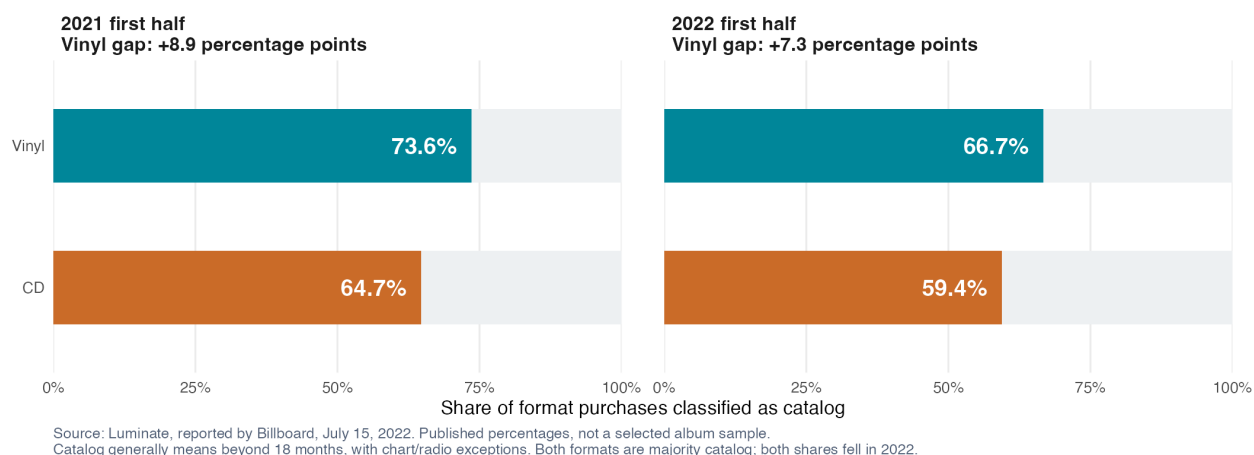


Figure 5. Catalog shares within each format, first-half 2021 and 2022. Vinyl skews older in both periods, although catalog's share falls in both formats.

A separate BuzzAngle report provides an earlier check: recordings older than *three years* accounted for 66.2% of vinyl purchases in 2018, versus 57.1% of CDs. This earlier report also shows older recordings taking a larger share of vinyl purchases than CD purchases.

## The distinction also appears among recordings over three years old

2018 U.S. sales: deep catalog (>156 weeks) accounted for 66.2% of vinyl and 57.1% of CD purchases

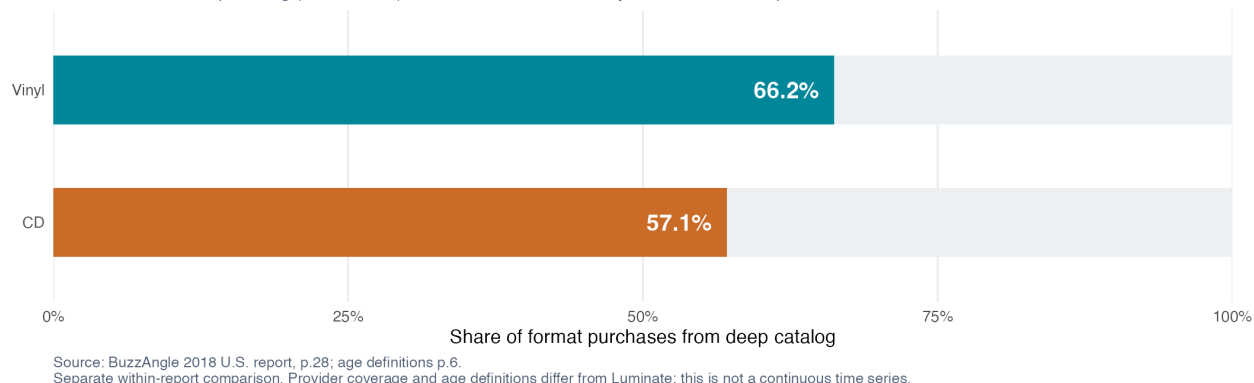


Figure 6. Recordings older than 156 weeks accounted for 66.2% of vinyl purchases and 57.1% of CD purchases in 2018—a 9.1-percentage-point gap. Source: BuzzAngle; separate from the later Luminate comparisons.

The finding is the difference between formats: established recordings account for more of vinyl's purchases than CD's. Opening-week comparisons miss that difference in the sales mix. This does not establish that individual albums age better on vinyl or that catalog drove vinyl's national growth; catalog's share actually fell in both formats between the two Luminate periods.

Vinyl's advantage was not simply about how strongly an album launched, but about the mix of recordings people continued to buy. Why might familiar recordings have particular appeal on vinyl? Larger artwork and display potential may make a loved album worth owning even when streaming handles everyday listening.

CD successes sharpen that hypothesis. AC/DC's *Power Up* sold 71,000 CDs against 16,000 vinyl copies in its U.S. debut week. Its deluxe CD offered an illuminated logo and built-in speaker, while vinyl offerings merely included colored records and gatefold packaging. The track lists were identical across formats. [Sales and product details](#)

Kelly Clarkson's *Chemistry* sold 18,000 CDs versus 7,500 vinyl copies in opening week. CD offerings included signed copies and a poster edition; reported vinyl differentiation centered on colors and alternative artwork instead of additional mementos. Neither example isolates the extras' effect: sales include standard CDs, and price, audience, and availability also matter. However, they suggest that a CD can still earn a place on the shelf—especially when it offers fans a keepsake alongside the music.

[Sales and product details](#)

These examples also prevent an overly simple ending in which vinyl becomes merchandise and CDs become obsolete. Both can carry artwork, signatures and other tangible associations with the artist. The useful distinction may be how effectively the edition expresses that connection for its audience, rather than whether it is a large record or a small disc.

The commercial implication is to evaluate physical albums on two dimensions: the recording's continuing appeal and what the edition offers its buyer. Vinyl's stronger catalog mix suggests opening-week comparisons can overlook an enduring market. Collectible CD successes caution against treating that opportunity as a property of vinyl alone. The question worth carrying forward is which familiar recordings people want to own—and what makes a particular edition worth choosing.

## Appendix — sources, methods and supporting evidence

The Tableau dashboard accompanies this memo. Supporting notebooks and data are retained in the evidence archive, including exploratory findings that did not support the initial hypothesis. Web-source links below are clickable; local research-file names refer to the archive.

**RIAA: [2025 annual report](#)**, story notebook, calculation table. Figure 1 uses legacy units through 2023 and revised annual-report units for 2024–2025. The legacy retail revenue series and current wholesale revenue series are not spliced. RIAA industry estimates and Luminate album-level retail tracking are different measurement systems. The volume decomposition is an accounting identity, not causal attribution.

**Price analysis:** Annual-change regression. Revenue per unit shares a units denominator with the relative-demand outcome; its coefficient is not a causal price elasticity. The memo uses the descriptive revenue-per-copy comparison instead.

**Genre: [Country source](#)**, exploratory genre notebook. The earlier broad-genre upper bound is retained for transparency, not used to reject genre composition as an important contributor. The country example establishes within-genre change, not the cause of that change.

**First-week models:** Regression notebook. Full collection: 132 albums / 201 observations, including 80 CD and 121 vinyl rows. Complete priced pairs: 41 albums / 82 observations. Album indicators absorb shared characteristics, not format-specific supply or merchandising. The paired price-adjusted coefficient is +17,193 vinyl copies,  $p=.600$ . This is an association, not a causal format effect. Current advertised-price proxies and documented historical prices are distinguished in the underlying data.

**Launch-to-later evidence:** Expanded notebook, case data, summary. Original eight: six increases, two declines, mean +5.83 points. Nine cases with reported numerical counts: six increases, three declines, mean -4.71 points. Figure 4 preserves the original motivating cohort plus the requested CD-bound case; it is not the complete expanded sample. Cumulative totals include launch week. Common observation windows within cases do not establish equal in-stock exposure or uniform elapsed horizons across albums.

**Bounded cases:** Happier Than Ever has 252,000 later vinyl copies and a conservative CD ceiling of 187,500, implying a vinyl premium of at least 34.4%; its launch premium was approximately 58.7%, so the direction of change is unresolved. The expanded notebook also retains I’m the Problem with a vinyl upper bound. Cutoffs are bounds, not estimated sales or confidence intervals; missing formats are never assigned zero. List completeness, rounding and album grouping matter.

**Catalog breakdown:** Source data, [Luminate/ Billboard report](#). These historical shares do not establish the 2025–2026 mix. No significance test treats individual purchased copies as independent observations: rounded market aggregates do not supply a defensible sampling variance, and sales cluster by album, artist and campaign. The reported gaps are descriptive.

**Earlier catalog check:** [BuzzAngle 2018 report](#), pp.6 and 28. Deep catalog is older than 156 weeks. Coverage and age definitions differ from Luminate; the measures are not merged. Separate chart.

**Older-title histories:** Expanded evidence, graph. The expanded comparable table contains twenty title-year observations across ten normalized pre-2021 titles; nine have a supported vinyl lead at least once and seven in multiple observed years. Selection through vinyl rankings prevents population inference. These purchases concern new copies of old recordings, not resale activity. The underlying notebook records sources and cutoff assumptions.

**CD examples:** Format-wide totals cannot identify sales of the deluxe editions alone. Contemporary product descriptions do not establish that every vinyl offering lacked extras. These are selected illustrations of product differentiation, not estimates of a packaging effect or evidence that catalog status caused CD performance.

## Price and format models: the same 41 albums

Both models use the same 82 observations and 35 artists. The outcome is first-week units in thousands; price is the advertised price in U.S. dollars. CD is the reference format.

$$\text{Sales} = \text{intercept} + \beta_V \times \text{Vinyl} + \beta_P \times \text{Price}$$

The second specification replaces the common intercept with a separate intercept for each album:

$$\text{Sales} = \text{album intercept} + \beta_V \times \text{Vinyl} + \beta_P \times \text{Price}$$

| Model                             | Predictor      | Estimate<br>(thousand copies) | 95% confidence interval | p-value |
|-----------------------------------|----------------|-------------------------------|-------------------------|---------|
| Format + price                    | Vinyl          | -69.46                        | -166.04 to 27.11        | .153    |
| Format + price                    | Price, per \$1 | +4.94                         | -2.11 to 11.99          | .164    |
| Format + price + album indicators | Vinyl          | +17.19                        | -48.80 to 83.19         | .600    |
| Format + price + album indicators | Price, per \$1 | -0.78                         | -6.81 to 5.26           | .796    |

Intervals use CR1 standard errors clustered by artist and a t reference with 34 degrees of freedom. The sign change is descriptive; it is not a test establishing a difference between the two coefficients. Neither price coefficient differs conclusively from zero. These are conditional associations, not causal demand elasticities. Album indicators do not absorb format-specific extras or supply constraints, and the data do not establish which omitted factors explain the pooled positive price association.

Sources: pooled estimates, album-indicator estimates, identical paired sample, chart summaries.